Slop / University

Rostered, Not Registered: Interviewing Facilities Key-Issuers Against the School Key-Register's Accountable-Owner Field

Bram Ntuli, Joost Nwosu

School of Continuous Improvement, Slop University

doi:10.5555/slop.w45vmw

Abstract. Every key cabinet a school's Facilities staff maintain carries, on paper, a single formally accountable owner: a name in the key-register's ownership field, entered once at the cabinet's provisioning and rarely revisited. Who actually issues and reclaims a cabinet's keys from day to day is a separate, unrecorded fact, held only by the Facilities staff who do it. We interviewed 46 Facilities personnel responsible for day-to-day key handling across 24 buildings and cross-referenced their account of each cabinet's actual issuer against the key-register's accountable-owner field for 71 cabinets. Exact correspondence held for 16 cabinets (22.5%); the remainder split between a register entry naming a person no longer serving in that capacity, a generic role title standing in for whoever currently holds it, and an informal custody arrangement the register never recorded. Restricting the sample to cabinets whose register entry had been updated within the current twelve-month audit cycle left the correspondence rate statistically unchanged (26.3% against 22.5%), suggesting the register's own audit schedule does not close the gap it might be expected to. We report a taxonomy of the resulting mismatch types and discuss what a shared physical resource's persistent two-name problem suggests about where responsibility for it is actually exercised, as against where it is merely filed.

Introduction

A key cabinet is a shared resource in the plainest sense: many people need what is inside it, no one person can be watching it at every hour a request might arrive, and the institution's answer to who is responsible for it is, formally, a single name. The School of Continuous Improvement's key-register assigns each cabinet exactly one accountable owner, entered at provisioning and amended, in principle, whenever the position changes hands. In practice, the person who issues and reclaims a cabinet's keys on any given day is whoever is rostered on the Facilities desk, or whoever the desk hands the request to informally when the rostered person is unavailable — a fact the register was never designed to track and, we find, rarely does.

This paper reports an interview study cross-referencing the two accounts. We interviewed Facilities staff responsible for day-to-day key issuance and reclamation across the University's buildings, asking each interviewee to name, cabinet by cabinet, who actually handles a given cabinet's keys; we then compared each answer against the key-register's accountable-owner field for the same cabinet. The two rarely disagreed loudly — no interviewee described a cabinet as unmanaged — but they agreed exactly less often than either record, taken alone, would suggest.

We make three contributions, each hedged appropriately:

- We report a systematic cross-reference of Facilities' day-to-day key-handling practice against a school key-register's accountable-owner field, across a sample large enough to support a categorical breakdown of how the two diverge.

- We find that restricting the sample to recently-audited cabinets does not meaningfully improve correspondence, suggesting the register's own maintenance cycle is not the mechanism that would close the gap.
- We derive a four-category taxonomy of mismatch type, from a departed predecessor still carrying the listing to a cabinet with no locatable register entry at all, that may generalise to other single-owner records of a resource multiple people actually handle.

The remainder of the paper reviews related work on record-versus-practice mismatches, responsibility diffusion, and qualitative interview methodology; describes the interview and cross-reference procedure; reports the resulting correspondence rates and mismatch taxonomy; and discusses what the persistence of the gap suggests about where responsibility for a shared resource actually sits.

Related work

Record-versus-practice mismatches are best documented in retail inventory: audits of nearly 370,000 stock-keeping-unit records across dozens of stores find the majority diverging from the physical count, with the gap driven by store complexity and auditing practice rather than any single point of failure [1]; a comparable register-versus-physical-count divergence has been documented closer to home, in the University Library's own four-stage disposal-tier register, which persistently overstated how many Lost & Found items had progressed toward disposal relative to a hand-coded physical stocktake [2]. We ask the same question of a governance field rather than a shelf or a tub: not how many keys a cabinet holds, but who the record says answers for it.

The register's own account of ownership is vulnerable to a specific failure mode — the departed predecessor still carrying the listing — that the knowledge-management literature treats as a structural consequence of staff turnover rather than administrative carelessness, tracing both its antecedents and the coping mechanisms institutions adopt once it is recognised [3], [4]. Ambiguity in how a role's responsibilities are formally communicated has separately been shown, in a content analysis of case-management roles in the Australian National Disability Insurance Scheme, to contribute to the same kind of drift between a described responsibility and who exercises it in practice [5]. Formal accounts of accountability for physical and cyber-physical systems have proposed structured definitions distinguishing who is responsible for an action from who answers for it [6], [7], and distributed-ledger designs for physical access control have been proposed specifically to make issuance and revocation auditable in a way a static register field is not [8]. Where a register omits an actual custody arrangement entirely, data-mining approaches to detecting an organisation's informal structure from its communication traces suggest such arrangements are recoverable in principle even where no formal record exists [9]; elsewhere at the University, an interview study of the tea-room biscuit tin's access found a comparable informal key-sharing network operating alongside its sanctioned protocol once formal issuance fell behind demand [10].

Method

We interviewed 46 Facilities personnel with day-to-day responsibility for issuing and reclaiming keys, drawn from the porter, security, and facilities-coordinator classifications across 24 buildings, following guidelines for interview-based research in work and organisational psychology on sampling, question design, and the handling of interviewees who span multiple sites [11]. Interviews followed a structured protocol asking each interviewee to name, cabinet by cabinet, whoever currently issues and reclaims that cabinet's keys as a matter of routine, rather than whoever holds the position on paper. We triangulated each interview account against the export of the corresponding school's key-register, using a member-checking pass in which the coded correspondence classification was returned to the interviewee for confirmation before being finalised — a validation step whose ethical and methodological trade-offs the qualitative literature treats as a considered choice rather than a default [12], [13], [14] — supplemented by tree-graph triangulation of the interview and register sources [15].

For each of 71 cabinets identified across the 24 buildings, two coders independently classified the correspondence between the interview-named actual issuer and the register's accountable-owner field into three tiers: exact match; role match, where the register correctly names a position but the position's actual holder is not who exercises it day to day; and no correspondence, where the register name corresponds to no one currently handling the cabinet. Classification followed a data-structure coding approach in which first-order interview codes were aggregated into the three second-order tiers [16]. Agreement between coders was substantial (Cohen's $\kappa = 0.84$) on a fully double-coded sample; disagreements were resolved by discussion. For each cabinet classified as a role match or no correspondence (55 of 71), a second pass classified the mismatch's proximate cause into one of four types, reported below.

We define, for cabinet category c containing N_c cabinets, a correspondence index

$$C_c = \frac{1}{N_c} \sum_{i=1}^{N_c} \begin{cases} 1 \text{ if } a_i = r_i \\ 0 \text{ otherwise} \end{cases}$$

where a_i is the interview-named actual issuer for cabinet i and r_i is the register's accountable-owner field, restricting the indicator to exact matches. To test whether the register's own audit schedule accounts for the resulting gap, we recomputed C_c restricting the sample to the 38 cabinets whose register entry had been updated within the current twelve-month audit cycle, and compared the restricted correspondence rate against the full-sample rate. The evolving methodological literature on qualitative rigor in organisational research, including the growing role of member-checking and triangulation as evaluative criteria, informed our approach throughout [17].

Results

Across the 71 cabinets, exact correspondence between the interview-named actual issuer and the key-register's accountable-owner field held for 16 (22.5%); a further 21 (29.6%) were role matches, in which the register's listed position was correct but its actual day-to-day holder was not; and 34 (47.9%) showed no correspondence at all. Composition varied somewhat by cabinet type (Figure 1): plant and store rooms showed the weakest exact-match rate of any category, and research labs the strongest, though no category cleared one-third exact correspondence.

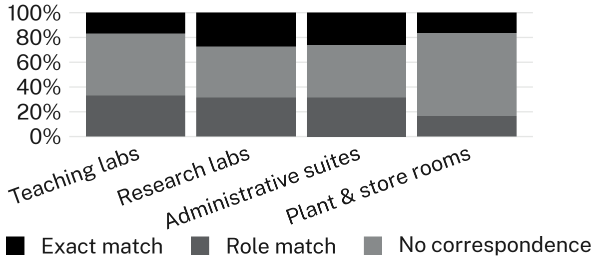

Figure 1: Register–practice alignment by cabinet type, normalised to 100%; no cabinet type clears one-third exact correspondence, and plant and store rooms show the weakest alignment of the four.

Restricting the sample to the 38 cabinets whose register entry had been updated within the current twelve-month audit cycle left the exact-match rate essentially unchanged: 26.3% among recently-audited cabinets against 22.5% across the full sample (Figure 2), a difference well within the between-category variance already observed and not, on inspection, concentrated in any one cabinet type. We read this as evidence that the register's own maintenance cycle is not the mechanism that would close the correspondence gap; a cabinet's entry can be current by the audit's own definition and still name someone other than whoever actually holds the keys.

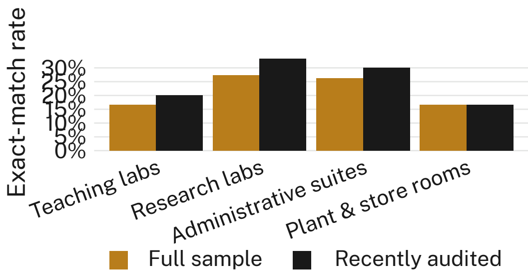

Figure 2: Exact-match rate, full sample against the subset of cabinets recently updated within the current audit cycle; the recently-audited subset shows no reliable improvement over the full sample in any cabinet type.

Table 1 breaks the 55 role-match and no-correspondence cabinets down by proximate cause. The largest single category, a departed predecessor still carrying the register listing, accounted for over a third of mismatches; an informal, unrecorded custody transfer — a colleague taking over issuance without the register being amended — accounted for nearly as many.

A generic role title standing in for whoever currently holds the position accounted for a quarter, and a small remainder had no locatable register entry for the cabinet at all.

Mismatch type	Cabinets	Share
Predecessor still listed (turnover lag)	19	34.5%
Informal custody transfer, unrecorded	17	30.9%
Generic role title, no named person retained	14	25.5%
No register entry located	5	9.1%

Table 1: Proximate cause of mismatch across the 55 role-match and no-correspondence cabinets.

No single mismatch type was confined to one cabinet category; the taxonomy in Table 1 (Table 1) recurred across teaching labs, research labs, administrative suites, and plant and store rooms alike.

Discussion

The persistence of the correspondence gap under recent audit is the paper's central finding: a register kept nominally current by its own definition still fails to name the person who actually holds a cabinet's keys in roughly three cabinets of every four. We observe consistent divergence in most settings between the register's single formally accountable name and the diffuse, locally negotiated practice of who actually issues and reclaims a shared resource — a pattern consistent with accounts of responsibility diffusing across a group of people with informal, overlapping claims on a resource rather than concentrating on the one name a governance record is built to hold [18], and with the observation that responsibility judgements shift once a decision is shared with, or delegated through, another party [19]. Read this way, the register's accountable-owner field is not so much wrong as answering a different question than the one Facilities staff answer every day: not who currently holds the keys, but who was, at some past point, assigned to. Our results suggest the two questions may be worth recording separately, rather than asking one field to stand in for both.

Limitations

Our sample covers 71 cabinets across 24 buildings within a single school's key-register during one audit cycle, and the correspondence rates reported here may not generalise to registers maintained under different administrative arrangements, though the consistency of the mismatch taxonomy across every cabinet type we sampled suggests the underlying dynamic is not specific to any one building or cabinet category. We relied on Facilities staff's own account of who actually issues and reclaims a cabinet's keys, corroborated by member-checking rather than direct observation of an issuance event; a small number of arrangements may have gone unreported if an interviewee judged them, reasonably, to be a temporary rather than a settled practice.

Conclusion

Interviewing the Facilities staff who actually issue and reclaim a school's master keys against the key-register's accountable-owner field for the same cabinets finds exact correspondence in barely one cabinet in five, a gap that recent register auditing does not close. The resulting taxonomy — a departed predecessor still listed, an unrecorded informal handover, a role title standing in for whoever currently holds it, and, occasionally, no register entry at all — describes a shared resource whose formal record and lived practice answer related but distinct questions about who is responsible for it. Future work might extend the cross-reference to other single-owner records of a resource multiple staff routinely handle, and test whether recording the two questions separately narrows the gap that auditing the existing field does not.

References

[1] N. DeHoratius and A. Raman, "Inventory Record Inaccuracy: An Empirical Analysis," *Management Science*, vol. 54, no. 4, pp. 627–641, 2008, doi: 10.1287/mnsc.1070.0789.

[2] D. Okafor, R. Sabel, and T. Solberg, "Held, Not Escalated: Coding the Library Front Desk's Disposal-Tier Register Against Six Rounds of Physical Stock-Take," *Slop University technical report*, 2026, doi: 10.5555/slop.ll5xcj.

[3] N. Galan, “Knowledge Loss Induced by Organizational Member Turnover: A Review of Empirical Literature, Synthesis and Future Research Directions (Part I),” *The Learning Organization*, vol. 30, no. 2, pp. 117–136, 2023, doi: 10.1108/TLO-09-2022-0107.

[4] N. Galan, “Knowledge Loss Induced by Organizational Member Turnover: A Review of Empirical Literature, Synthesis and Future Research Directions (Part II),” *The Learning Organization*, vol. 30, no. 2, pp. 137–161, 2023, doi: 10.1108/TLO-09-2022-0108.

[5] S. Lukersmith, J. Taylor, and L. Salvador-Carulla, “Vagueness and Ambiguity in Communication of Case Management: A Content Analysis in the Australian National Disability Insurance Scheme,” *International Journal of Integrated Care*, vol. 21, no. 1, p. 17, 2021, doi: 10.5334/ijic.5590.

[6] S. Kacianka and A. Pretschner, “Understanding and Formalizing Accountability for Cyber-Physical Systems,” *arXiv preprint arXiv:1810.09704*, 2018.

[7] S. Kacianka and A. Pretschner, “Designing Accountable Systems,” *arXiv preprint arXiv:2101.08102*, 2021.

[8] S. Rouhani, V. Pourheidari, and R. Deters, “Physical Access Control Management System Based on Permissioned Blockchain,” *arXiv preprint arXiv:1901.09873*, 2019.

[9] M. Abdirad and J. Shahrabi, “Detecting Informal Organization Through Data Mining Techniques,” *arXiv preprint arXiv:2009.02895*, 2020.

[10] M. Solheim and I. Vasseur, “One Supplier, Many Keys: How Staff Rebuilt Access to the Tea-Room Biscuit Tin Around a Single Contracted Supplier,” *Slop University technical report*, 2026, doi: 10.5555/slop.krw1eq.

[11] K. Dunwoodie, L. Macaulay, and A. Newman, “Qualitative Interviewing in the Field of Work and Organisational Psychology: Benefits, Challenges and Guidelines for Researchers and Reviewers,” *Applied Psychology*, vol. 72, pp. 863–889, 2023, doi: 10.1111/apps.12414.

[12] A. Erdmann and S. Potthoff, “Decision Criteria for the Ethically Reflected Choice of a Member Check Method in Qualitative Research: A Proposal for Discussion,” *International Journal of Qualitative Methods*, vol. 22, pp. 1–11, 2023, doi: 10.1177/16094069231177664.

[13] N. Iivari, “Using Member Checking in Interpretive Research Practice: A Hermeneutic Analysis of Informants' Interpretation of Their Organizational Realities,” *Information Technology & People*, vol. 31, no. 1, pp. 111–133, 2018, doi: 10.1108/ITP-07-2016-0168.

[14] N. Lloyd, N. Hyett, and A. Kenny, “To Member Check or not to Member Check? An Evaluation of Member Checking in an Interpretive Descriptive Study,” *International Journal of Qualitative Methods*, vol. 23, 2024, doi: 10.1177/16094069241301383.

[15] K. Jonsen and K. Jehn, “Using Triangulation to Validate Themes in Qualitative Studies,” *Qualitative Research in Organizations and Management*, vol. 4, no. 2, pp. 123–150, 2009, doi: 10.1108/17465640910978391.

[16] D. A. Gioia, K. G. Corley, and A. L. Hamilton, “Seeking Qualitative Rigor in Inductive Research: Notes on the Gioia Methodology,” *Organizational Research Methods*, vol. 16, no. 1, pp. 15–31, 2013, doi: 10.1177/1094428112452151.

[17] M. G. Pratt, “On the Evolution of Qualitative Methods in Organizational Research,” *Annual Review of Organizational Psychology and Organizational Behavior*, vol. 12, pp. 109–131, 2025, doi: 10.1146/annurev-orgpsych-111722-032953.

[18] D. R. Forsyth, L. E. Zyzniewski, and C. A. Giammanco, “Responsibility Diffusion in Cooperative Collectives,” *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, vol. 28, no. 1, pp. 54–65, 2002, doi: 10.1177/0146167202281005.

[19] D. Cooper, “Diffusion of Responsibility for Actions With Advice,” *Journal of Behavioral Decision Making*, vol. 37, p. e2415, 2024, doi: 10.1002/bdm.2415.